Anxiety

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Symptoms

- Constant feeling of dread, racing thoughts or feeling tense and unable to relax.
- Heart palpitations, sweating, shaking or shortness of breath.
- Avoiding situations or places to escape the worry.

Age & Gender

- Can develop at any age, though frequently starts in adolescence.
- Females are roughly twice as likely to be diagnosed as males.

Common myths

- It's a medical condition, not drama or attention-seeking.
- People can't just choose to stop feeling anxious or stop worrying.
- Panic attacks feel life-threatening. They aren’t an overreaction.

Diagnosis

- GP or psychiatrist assessment using questionnaires.
- Generalised anxiety disorder is diagnosed when uncontrollable worry persists for 6 months and impacts daily life.

Professional support

- CBT helps change negative thought patterns.
- Medication can manage physical symptoms.
- Mindfulness and exercise support self-care.

How to help

- Listen without judging or saying 'just calm down'.
- Ask what helps them during a panic attack before one happens.
- Understand that plans may change last minute if they feel overwhelmed.

This information isn't a diagnostic tool. If you recognise these symptoms in yourself or others, please contact a doctor.